02-1/81-08-11

SPEECH BY PRIME MINISTER LEE KUAN YEW
AT DINNER GIVEN IN HONOUR OF
H.E. MR ZHAO ZIYANG, PREMIER OF THE
PEOPLE'S REPUBLIC OF CHINA
ON TUESDAY, 11 AUG 81, AT THE ISTANA

It is a great honour for me and my colleagues to reciprocate the warm and generous hospitality extended to my delegation and me when I visited the People's Republic of China in November last year. For many years, official contacts between us were unthinkable heresies. China and Singapore were positioned at opposing ends of an irreconcilable social and political system, supposedly in a state of permanent conflict.

Since the first Ministerial meeting in March 1975, we now know that we share several common interests, despite major differences in social and political systems and objectives; we harbour few misconceptions, and even less illusions, of each other.

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China and ASEAN have worked together to achieve several common objectives over Kampuchea. Both sides want a Kampuchea freed of Vietnamese domination and occupation. Some cynics would say that once the common threat posed by this Vietnamese occupation, backed by the Soviet Union, is removed,

relations between China and ASEAN will revert to one of basic irreconcilable antagonism, accompanied by subversion.

But if super-power intrusion into the area is to be avoided, a development not sought by ASEAN, nor welcomed by China, the cooperation that now exists between China and the ASEAN countries can and must continue after the Vietnamese occupation of Kampuchea is ended.

Much will depend on whether in the meantime China and ASEAN can build up trust and confidence in their common long-term interests in economic cooperation and genuine political non-interference in the internal affairs of ASEAN countries. It is infinitely better if common aspirations, not common threats, bring us together. The future that China once envisaged of fraternal communist parties taking over control of ASEAN countries was an is too simplistic. It is as unlikely as it is unhelpful in establishing normal government-to-government relations.

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If China can cooperate with US, Japan, and Western Europe, surely there can be a basis for long-term cooperation between a Marxist-Maoist China and the non-communist, free-market countries of ASEAN. One example of anticipating and avoiding suspicion and distrust is over the long-term solution to

Kampuchea. We both agree that Vietnamese occupation will turn out to be a costly mistake for Vietnam and for Vietnam's backers, the Soviet Union. We are not, however, in total agreement on the details of what will follow a Vietnamese withdrawal. Nevertheless, it is important that we do not allow these differences to be exploited by the Vietnamese or the Soviets. And it is as important that we resolve it in accordance with the full spirit of the Declaration of the special International Conference on Kampuchea last month at the UN.

The peoples of East and Southeast Asia have great prospects for peace, economic development and prosperity. If we are to catch up with the industrial countries, we have to break out of our ideological mindsets and put aside our prejudices. We need to concentrate our energies on the welfare of our peoples, not waste time and resources on countering propaganda and subversion. When a big nation, like China, sincerely accepts and respects the integrity and independence of smaller nations of East and Southeast Asia, then there will be few opportunities for other great powers to threaten any country, either directly or by proxy. This is a worthy common aspiration, one upon which we can build an enduring and cooperative relationship, a relationship which will ensure stability, encourage economic cooperation and bring benefits to all our peoples. The alternative is to have the area open to super-power intervention and manipulation.

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For a start, it helps to understand the hopes, fears and pre-occupations of the 250 million people who comprise ASEAN. None of the ASEAN countries has any need for communism or communist parties to bring about a better society and a better economic life for its peoples. Every ASEAN government is convinced that its own communists are threats only because of outside assistance and interference.

This is the nub of the problem. Your Vice-Chairman, Deng Xiaoping, had often urged your people to seek truth from the facts. This is the kind of language I understand. Let us deal with facts, not fiction. The facts require that we give no cause for suspicion of each other's ultimate intentions, so that we can continue to work together after the Vietnamese occupation of Kampuchea is ended.

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Finally, once again I extend a warm welcome to you and your delegation to Singapore. I hope your visit will establish that there is a common need for long-term cooperation between China and ASEAN to achieve higher common objectives: the security, stability and progress of China, of ASEAN, and of all the countries of East and Southeast Asia, including, eventually, the countries of Indo-China.

Now, may I ask you all to join me in a toast to the prosperity of the People's Republic of China and the happiness of her people; to better understanding and cooperation between the governments of the People's Republic of China and Singapore; to the health of the Chairman of the Standing Committee of the National People's Congress, Mr Ye Jianying; and to the health of Premier Zhao Ziyang.

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